5.
Content Marketing & Influencer Marketing

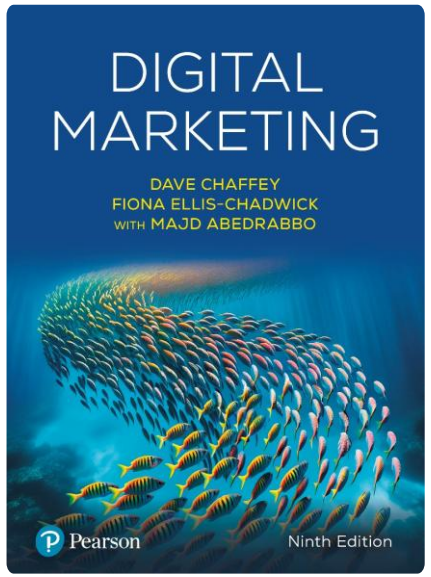


Module Structure

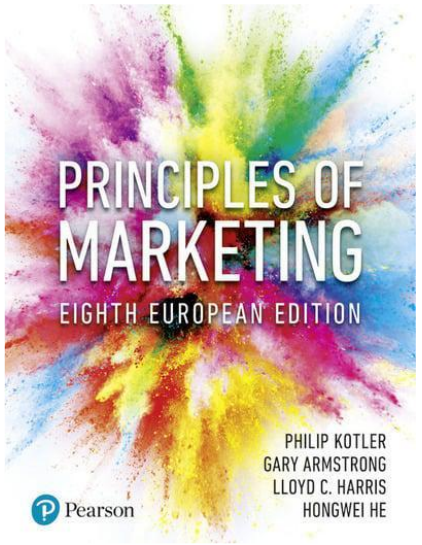
Week No.	Lecture Topic
1	Introduction: Traditional Marketing vs Digital Marketing
2	Marketing Environment in the Digital Age
3	Segmentation, Targeting, and Positioning in the Digital Age
4	Customer Engagement and Social Media
5	Content Marketing and Influencer Marketing
6	Consumer Behaviour and Customer Insight in the Digital Age
7	Search Marketing and Online Advertising
8	Email Marketing and Digital Customer Relationship Management
9	Online PR and Crisis Management
10	Marketing Research in the Digital Age
11	Ethics & The Future of Digital Marketing
12	Discussion Forum. Assignment Q&A

Recommended Reading

Chapter 9



Chapter 14



Why is this lecture relevant?



Structure for the assignment:

Title page

Introduction

A brief introduction to Popcorn Kitchen and the relevant UK industry.

(Roughly 300 words)

Digital challenges and opportunities

Overview of two key challenges and two key opportunities that Popcorn Kitchen faces in the digital age.

(Roughly 400 words)

Target market & Customer persona profile

Identify and justify the segment to target (e.g., demographics, behaviours, attitudes, motivations, brands, etc.). Based on this segment, create a persona profile (visual format) for Popcorn Kitchen in the UK. The persona profile should reflect an existing segment and be based on research. Justify your choices.

(Roughly 500 words)

Customer engagement: Conceptualisation and evaluation of strategies

Define customer engagement and its dimensions. Considering the customer persona, evaluate Popcorn Kitchen's digital marketing strategies (e.g., content development strategy, customer experience strategy, social media strategies, etc.) used in the UK to engage with customers in light of the digital customer literature. Practical observations and examples of Popcorn Kitchen's customer engagement should be used to justify the arguments.

(Roughly 1200 words)

Recommendations

Considering the existing literature/theories, and the customer engagement strategies discussed in the previous section, suggest recommendations for the business to enhance customer engagement. Recommendations should be realistic and suitable for implementation over the next 6-12 months and should reflect informed judgement rather than a descriptive list of digital tools or tactics. Be creative and justify your recommendations.

(Roughly 600 words)

References

Appendix

Agenda

- Content Marketing
  - Importance
  - Content Marketing Funnel
  - Strategies
- Influencer Marketing
  - Importance
  - Types of Influencers
  - Benefits & Threats

Content Marketing

Heaven vs. Hell – Digital Media



What is Content Marketing?



What is Content Marketing?

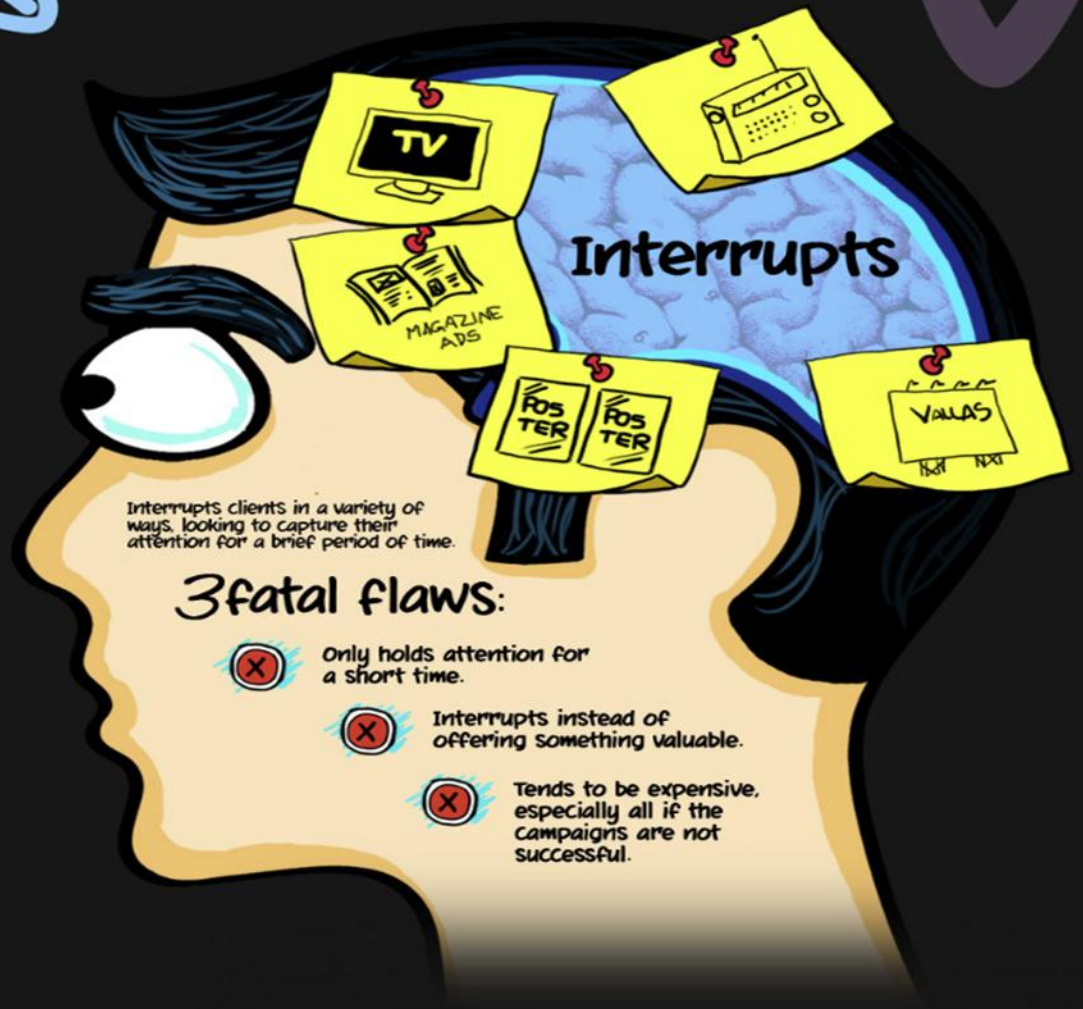
“Content marketing is a strategic marketing approach focused on creating and distributing valuable, relevant, and consistent content to attract and retain a clearly defined audience — and, ultimately, to drive profitable customer action.” (Content Marketing Institute, 2024)

- Can leverage most channels
- Useful independent of buying stage (from awareness to retention)

Traditional Marketing

VS

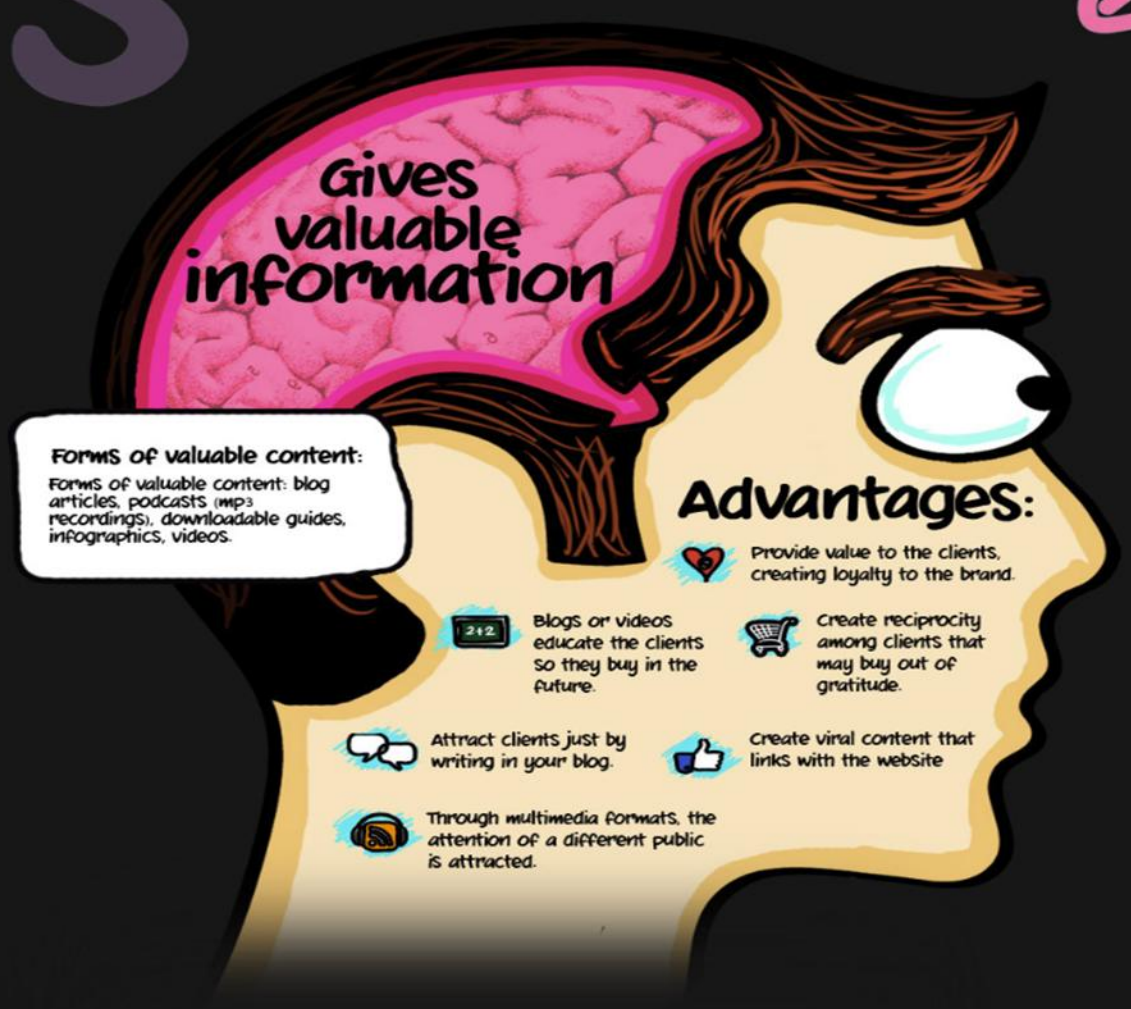
Content Marketing



Interrupts clients in a variety of ways, looking to capture their attention for a brief period of time.

3fatal flaws:

- Only holds attention for a short time.
- Interrupts instead of offering something valuable.
- Tends to be expensive, especially all if the campaigns are not successful.



Forms of valuable content:

Forms of valuable content: blog articles, podcasts (mp3 recordings), downloadable guides, infographics, videos.

Advantages:

- Provide value to the clients, creating loyalty to the brand.
- Blogs or videos educate the clients so they buy in the future.
- Create reciprocity among clients that may buy out of gratitude.
- Attract clients just by writing in your blog.
- Create viral content that links with the website
- Through multimedia formats, the attention of a different public is attracted.

What is Content Marketing? (Continued)

Content marketing...



is **not** about persuading consumers in an obvious manner



is about **creating valuable content** for the receiver

Blog posts

Webinars

Infographics

UGC

Videos

Checklists

Product demos

Case studies

Social media posts

Newsletters

Landing pages

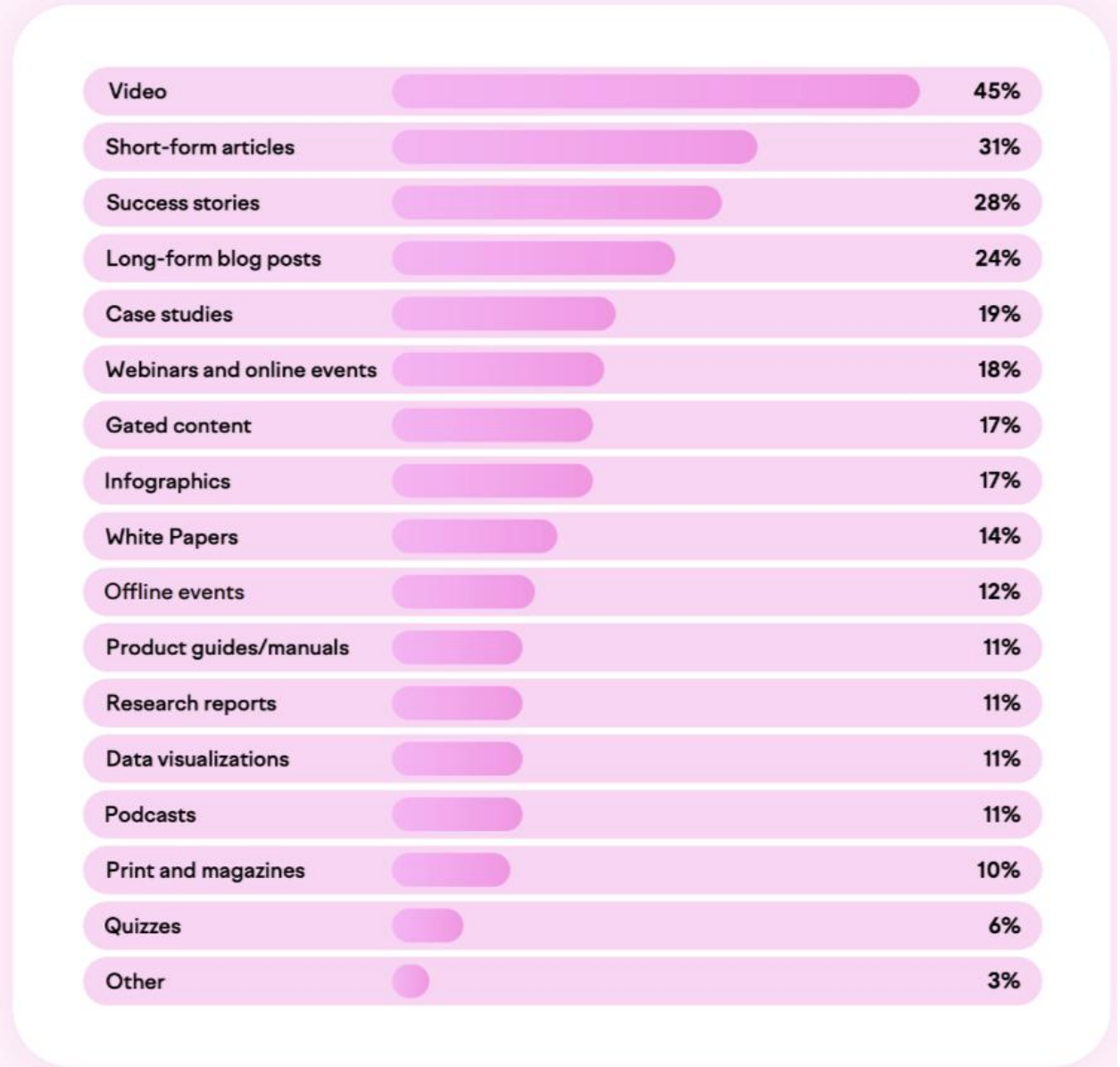
Podcasts

eBooks

White papers

Personalised emails

Most Successful Content Formats – 2025



Source: Semrush (2025)

Benefits of content marketing

Building customer relationships

- Providing **value** to customers
- **Educating** customers
- **Attracting** customers
- Enhanced **customer loyalty**

Driving search and sales performance

- Higher **search engine** rankings
- Increased **organic traffic**
- Increased **conversion rates**

Source: Semrush (2024)

The Content Marketing Funnel: How to Add Value

The Content Marketing Funnel

Entertain or educate

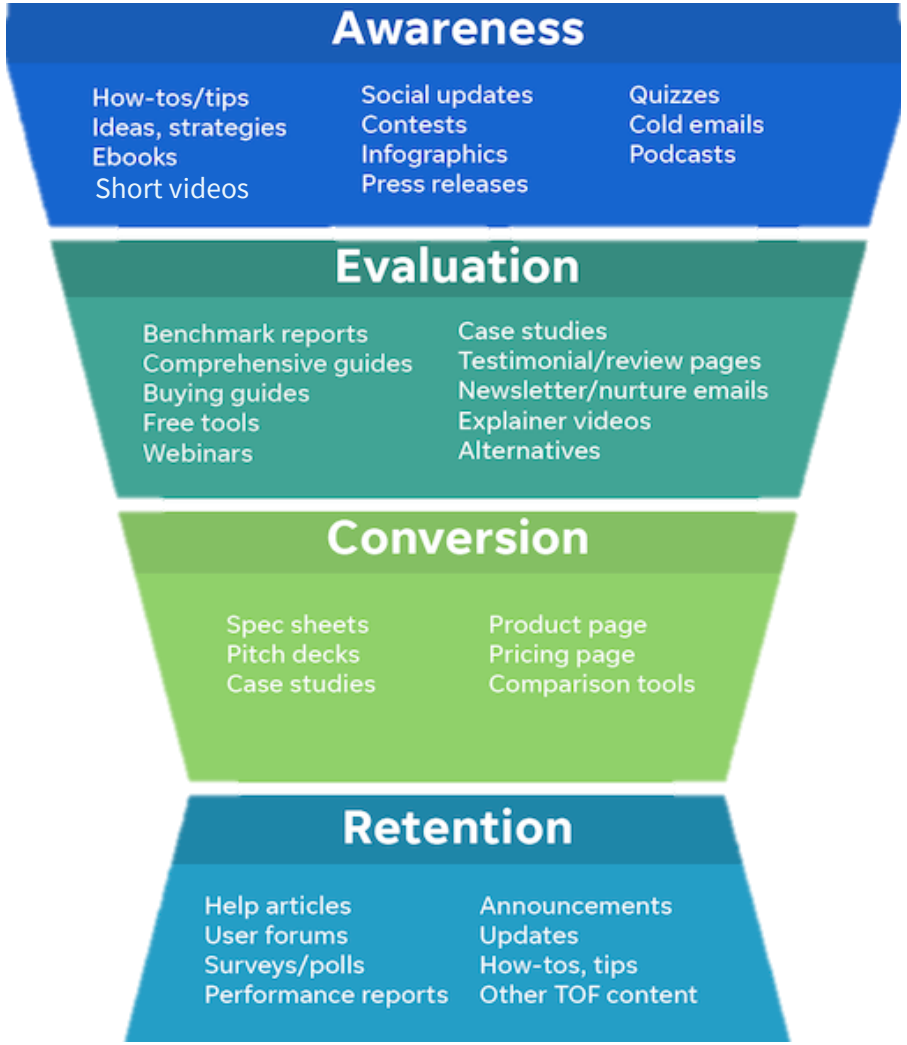
(Top of Funnel) TOFU
Awareness

(Middle of Funnel) MOFU
Evaluation

Inspire or convince

(Bottom of Funnel) BOFU
Conversion

Beyond Funnel
Retention



Source: McCormick (2022)

The Content Marketing Funnel - Awareness

At this stage, people are looking to learn and problem-solve. Your content serves to provide these answers while generating awareness of your brand.



Content tips

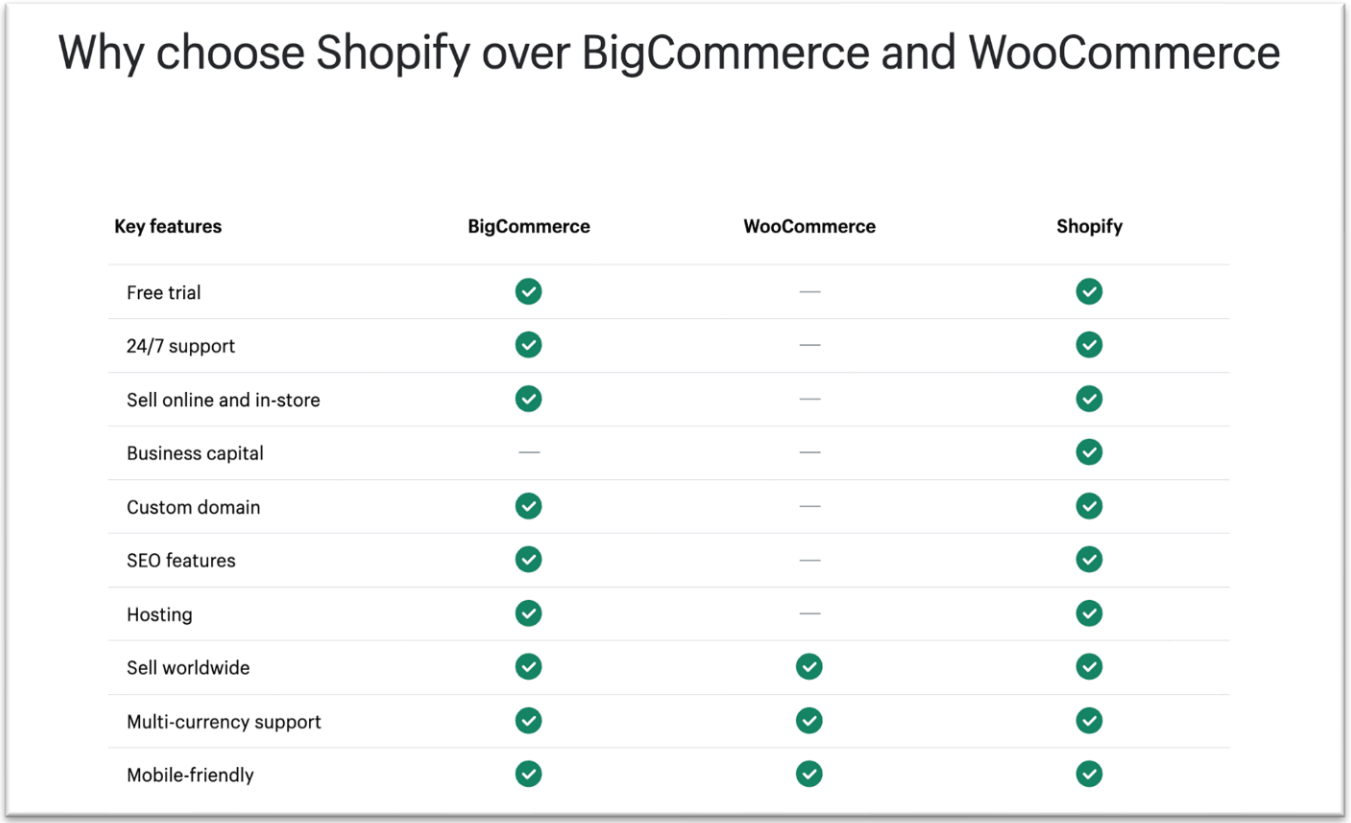
- **Disseminating broad information about your brand.**
- **Do your keyword research.**
- **Keep self-promotion to a minimum.**



Source: McCormick (2022)

The Content Marketing Funnel - Evaluation

People are aware of your brand and your solutions, and they're interested. They want to learn more about yours and how it compares to others. It helps build brand affinity.



Why choose Shopify over BigCommerce and WooCommerce

Key features	BigCommerce	WooCommerce	Shopify
Free trial	✓	—	✓
24/7 support	✓	—	✓
Sell online and in-store	✓	—	✓
Business capital	—	—	✓
Custom domain	✓	—	✓
SEO features	✓	—	✓
Hosting	✓	—	✓
Sell worldwide	✓	✓	✓
Multi-currency support	✓	✓	✓
Mobile-friendly	✓	✓	✓

Source: McCormick (2022)

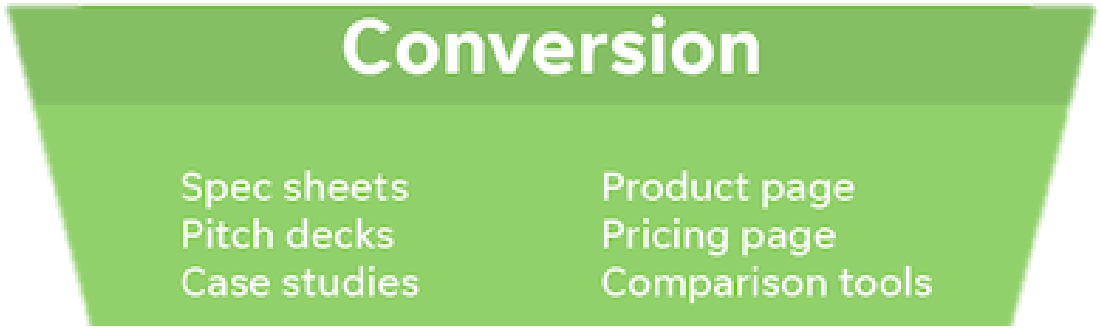


Content tips

- **Self-promoting products and services.**
- **Offering multiple touchpoints for customers to gain more precise brand information**

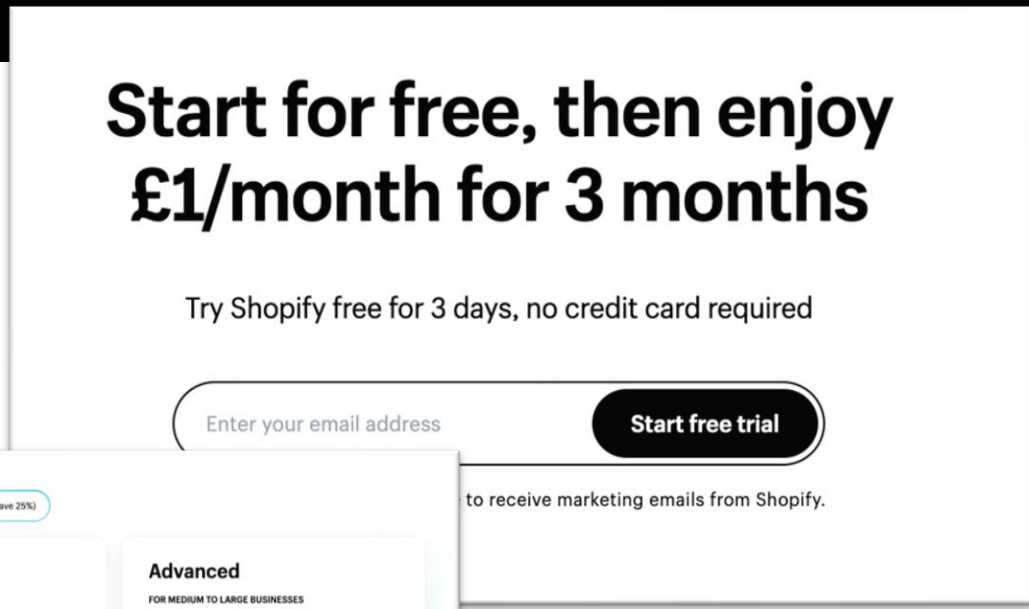
The Content Marketing Funnel - Conversion

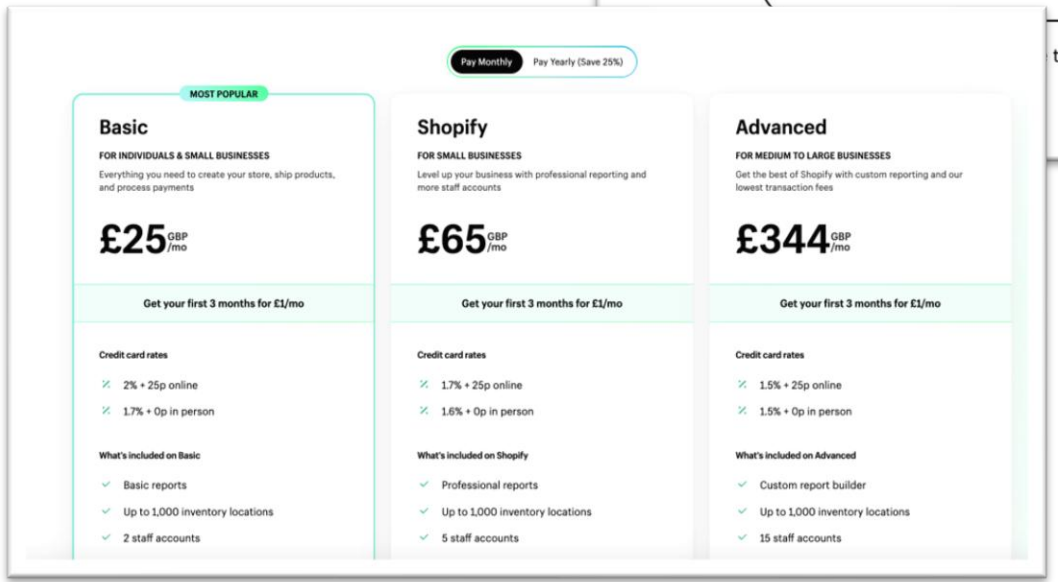
People are ready to buy. They're mostly committed to buying from you but may need a few extra nods of reassurance and/or help to decide what to buy.



Content tips

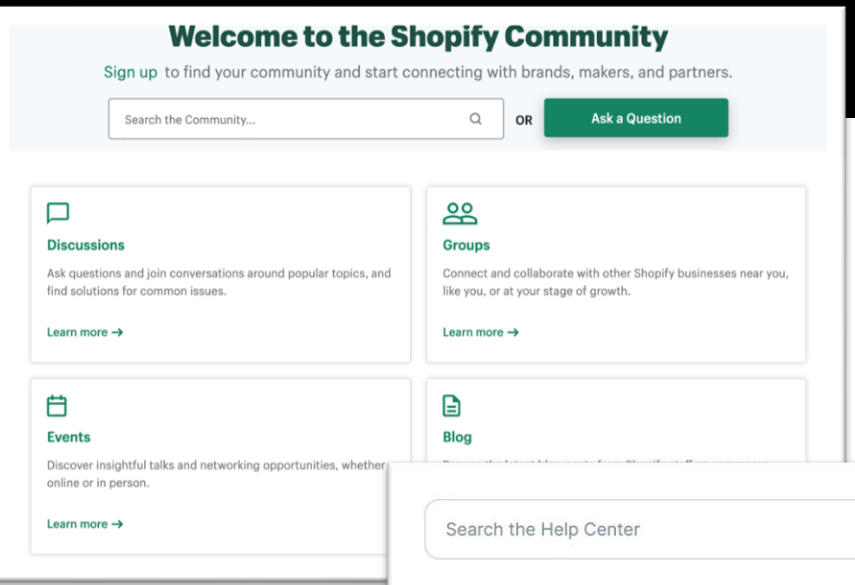
- **Using clear call-to-actions**
- **Consider offering small incentives (e.g., free shipping, discounts)**

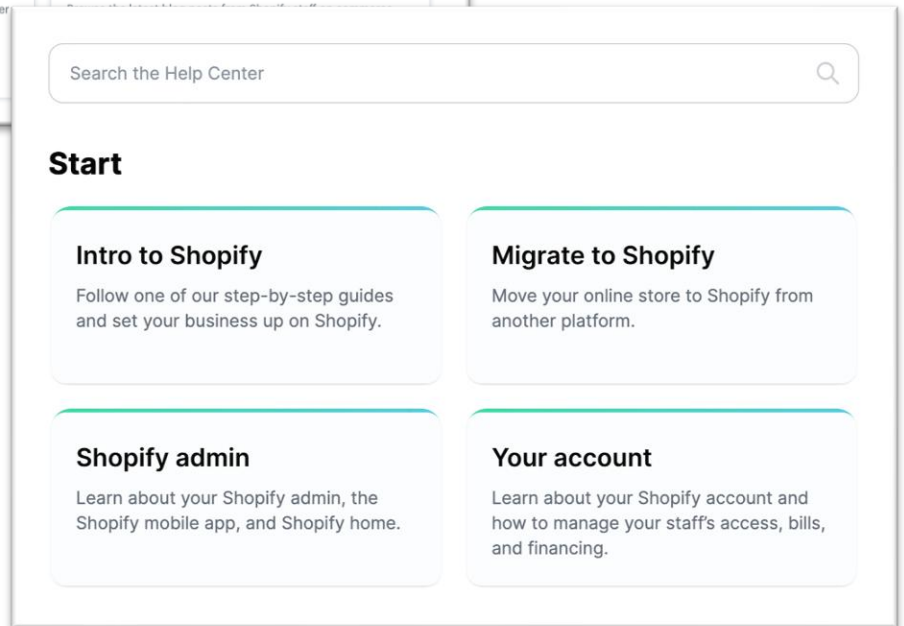




The Content Marketing Funnel - Retention

Your leads have become your customers. Your content here serves to keep them engaged, continue delivering value, and help them get the most out of your solution.







Content tips

- **Segmenting your audience further** to tailor your future communications
- **Continuing providing content about your brand** so they know your brand can still be useful
- **Encouraging them to share about their experience**



IT STARTS WITH *you*

In content marketing...

You need to **provide what your audience wants** – your audiences main concern is the value you bring them

Consider the 80/20 rule - 80% of your content should be about adding value (e.g., entertain, inspire, educate...), 20% to promote your products

Consider the marketing funnel to acknowledge your customers' problems and goals – and to tailor your content accordingly!

In content marketing...

You need to **provide what your audience wants** – your audiences main concern is the value you bring them

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Consider the **marketing funnel** to acknowledge your customers' **problems** and **goals** – and to **tailor your content** accordingly!

Optimising Content Distribution

Optimising Content Distribution



Optimising Content Distribution: TIMING

Timing: It is all about timing!

- When does your audience tend to be most active and engaged?
- When does your audience like to see certain topics?
- When does the brand need to publish and get the consumers engaged (pre-launch, post-launch)?



Optimising Content Distribution: RELEVANCE

Relevance: Do not let things come out of blue!

- How is the content related to your brand?
- How is the content related to your audiences?
- How is the content related to your marketing and business objectives?



Optimising Content Distribution: CONSISTENCY

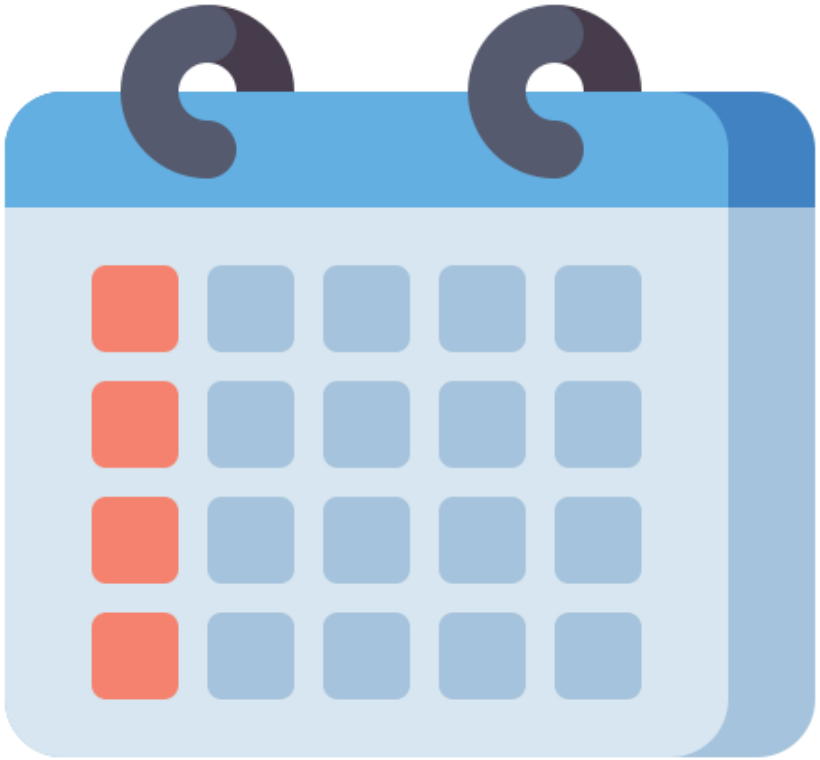
Consistency: Most consumers dislike a moody brand!

- Does your content deliver a consistent message?
- How does your content reflect the brand personality?
- How do you incorporate the innovation and creativity into forming consistent messages?



Optimising Content Distribution: CONSISTENCY

Content Planning



Have a content calendar – keep track of what content is to be published, on which platform, at what time, and other information that needs to be included

- **Saves time**
- Long-term **planning strategy & efficiency**

Optimising Content Distribution: ETHICS

Ethics: Never challenge your audience's bottom line of ethics!

- Does your content reflect social equity?
- Does your content recognise the social diversity?
- How does your content keep in line with the social norms?



Optimising Content Distribution: VARIETY

Variety: Bring surprising factors into your content!

- Does your content rely on a single form?
- Does your content give opportunities to interact with your audience?
- How does your content tell a story in the most appropriate form?



Optimising Content Distribution



…is all about publishing relevant, consistent and valuable content in various forms on different media at the right time!

Popular Strategies in Content Marketing

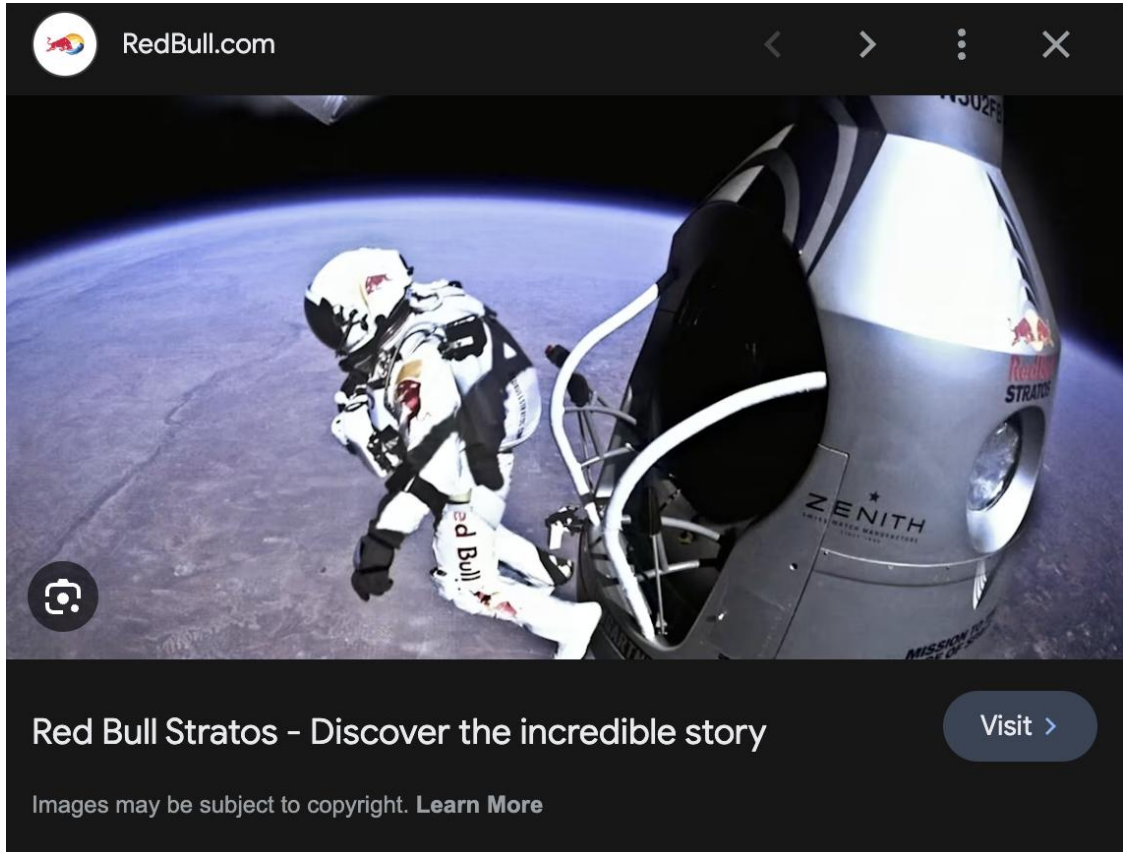
Storytelling

A Harvard Business Review article explains that **storytelling prompts the body to produce the neurochemical oxytocin, the "feel-good" hormone** (Zak, 2014).

It **also is released when people demonstrate trust or kindness** toward one another.

RedBull Stratos is a great example of content marketing storytelling.

https://www.redbull.com/gb-en/projects/red-bull-stratos



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Hz2F_S3Tl0Y



Newsjacking

Newsjacking is the process by which you **inject your ideas or angles into breaking news** to **generate media coverage** for yourself or your business.

Essentially you aim to *”Hop in the hype train”*

Pros:

Viral potential & linking

Timely & Relevant

Attitudes & purchase intention

Cons

Hit or miss

Risk of insensitivity

Newsjacking – #bendgate



- In 2014, Apple released the iPhone 6 and iPhone 6 Plus.
- Customers were complaining of the structural integrity of the phone (bending problem).
- News of this went viral and was known as #bendgate.
- The perfect opportunity to release newsjacking content.

Newsjacking – Examples







Clickbait

Clickbait is the use of headlines or imagery crafted specifically to **attract attention** and **encourage clicks**, often at the **cost of information accuracy**

Pros:

Higher CTR

Higher engagement

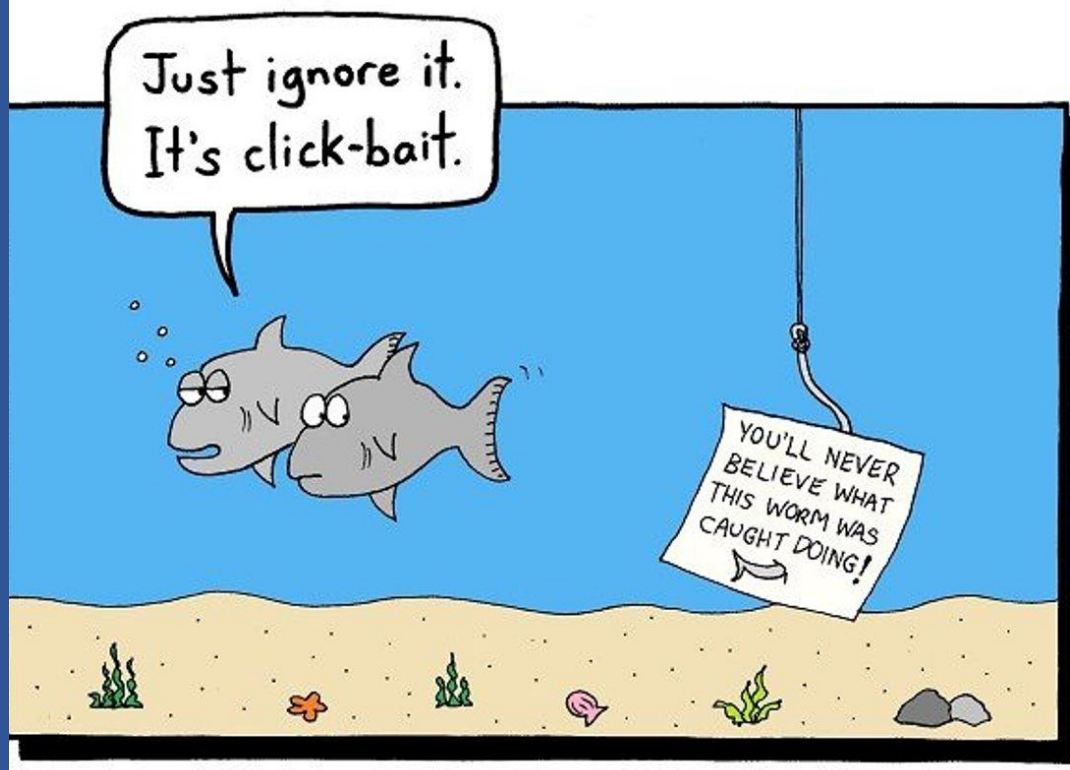
Higher virality

Cons

Erosion of trust

Reputation

Bounce Rates



Influencer Marketing

What is Influencer Marketing?

What is Influencer Marketing?

“A strategy in which a firm selects and incentivizes online influencers to engage their followers on social media in an attempt to leverage these influencers’ unique resources to promote the firm’s offerings, with the ultimate goal of enhancing firm performance.”
(Leung et al. 2022, p. 226)

- Generally considered a B2C strategy
- Built on parasocial relationships



The Parasocial Relationship

“Beyond” or “Beside”

PARASOCIAL

“The normative social relationship”



The Parasocial Relationship



The Followers

One-Sided Relationship
May feel like they ‘know’ the influencer
Higher level of trust towards influencer
Invests their attention and emotions
Fulfills influencer social validation or financially



The Influencer

Community-based Relationship
Does not personally know followers
Trusts followers as a whole
Invests their time and expertise
Fulfills follower escapism, entertainment, or information seeking

Social media influencers (SMIs) vs Celebrities

Celebrities

Have built recognition through other activities and **succeeded in institutional settings** (e.g. acting, music, sports)

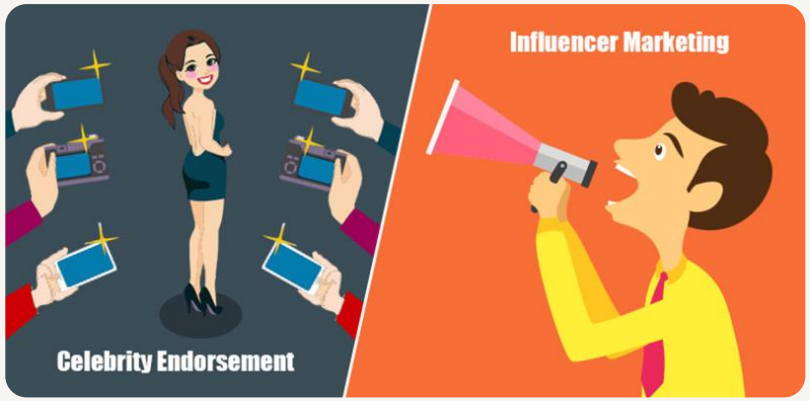
vs

Social media influencers

Accumulate followers by actively **sharing content on social media**

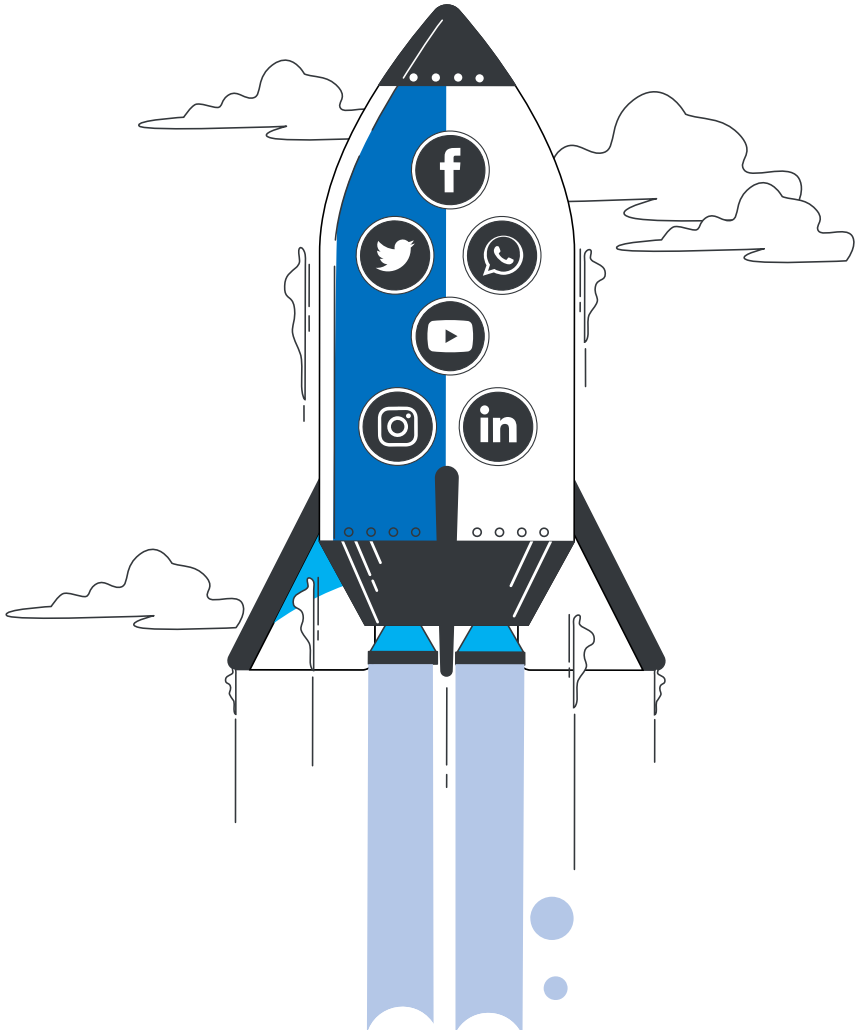
THE OVERLAP

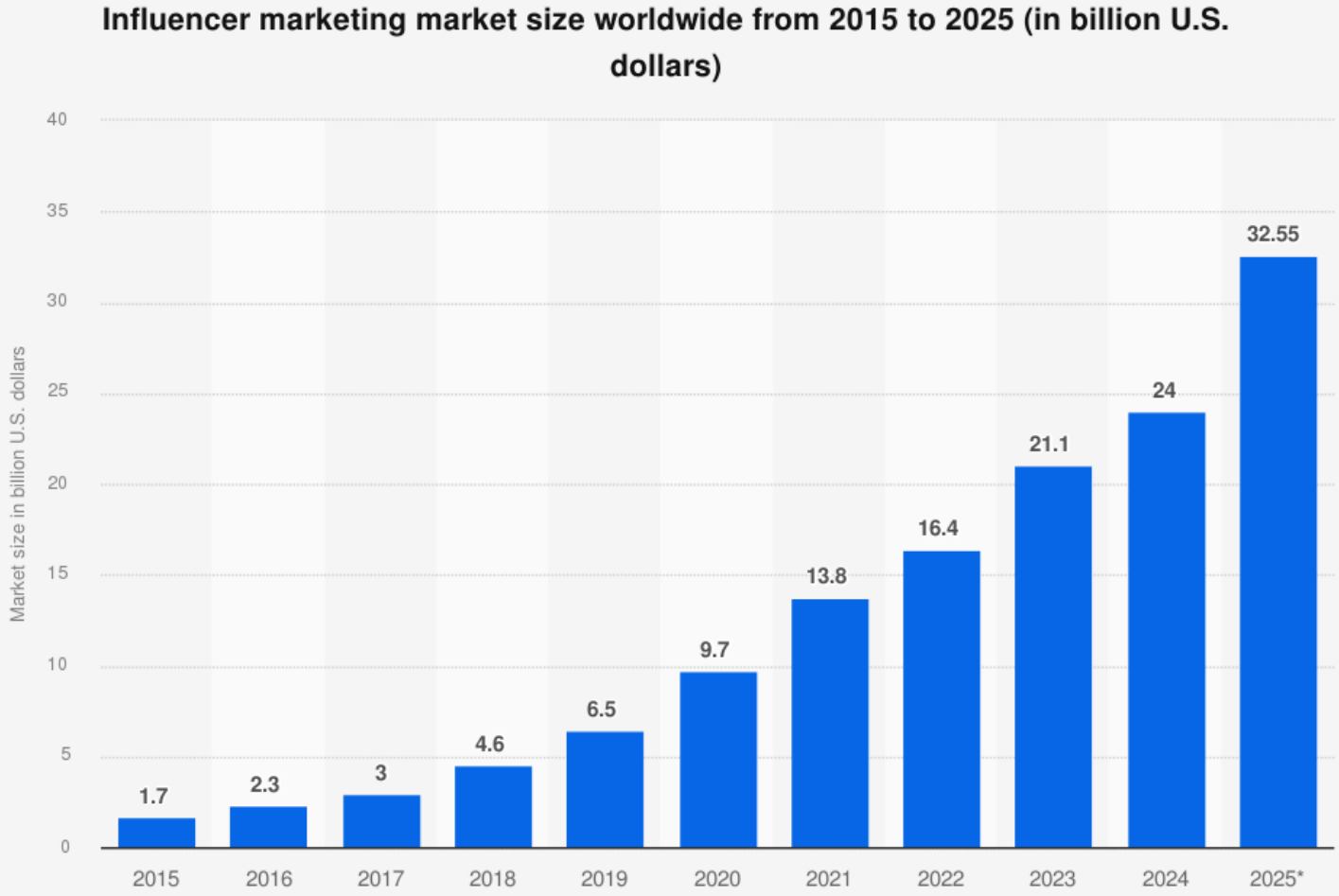
SMIs can also be traditional celebrities who have then developed a social media following



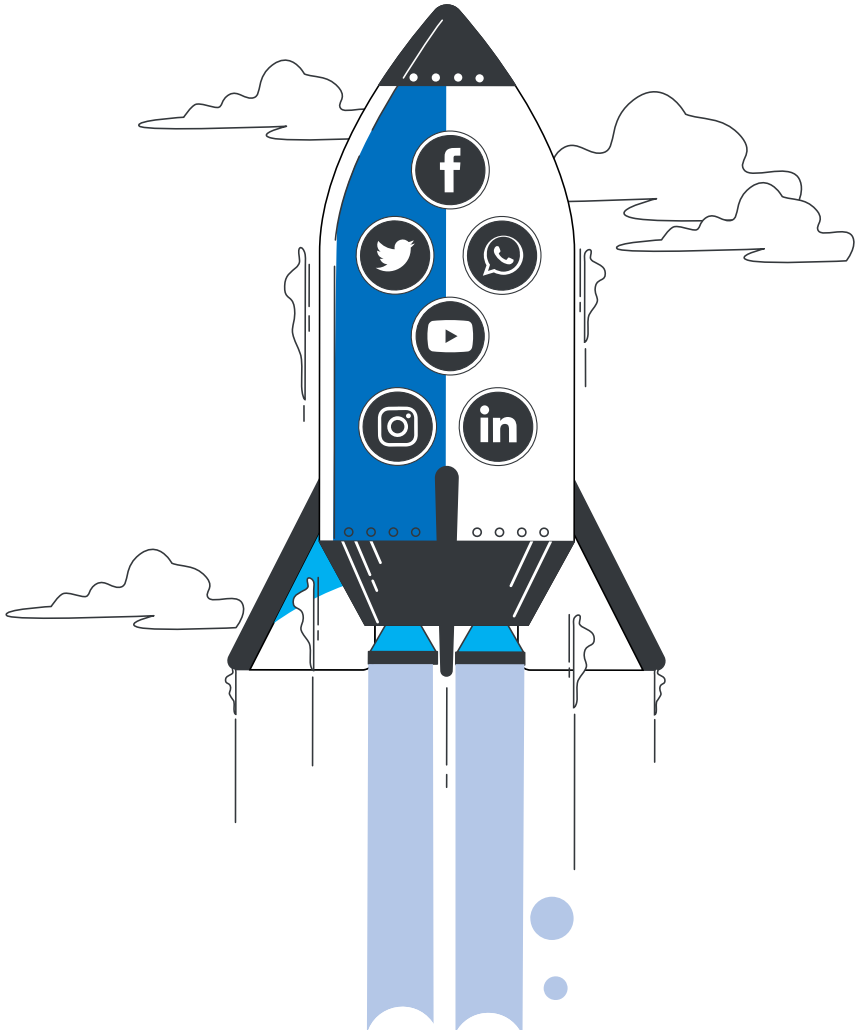
Source: Leung et al. (2022), Rundin and Colliander (2021)

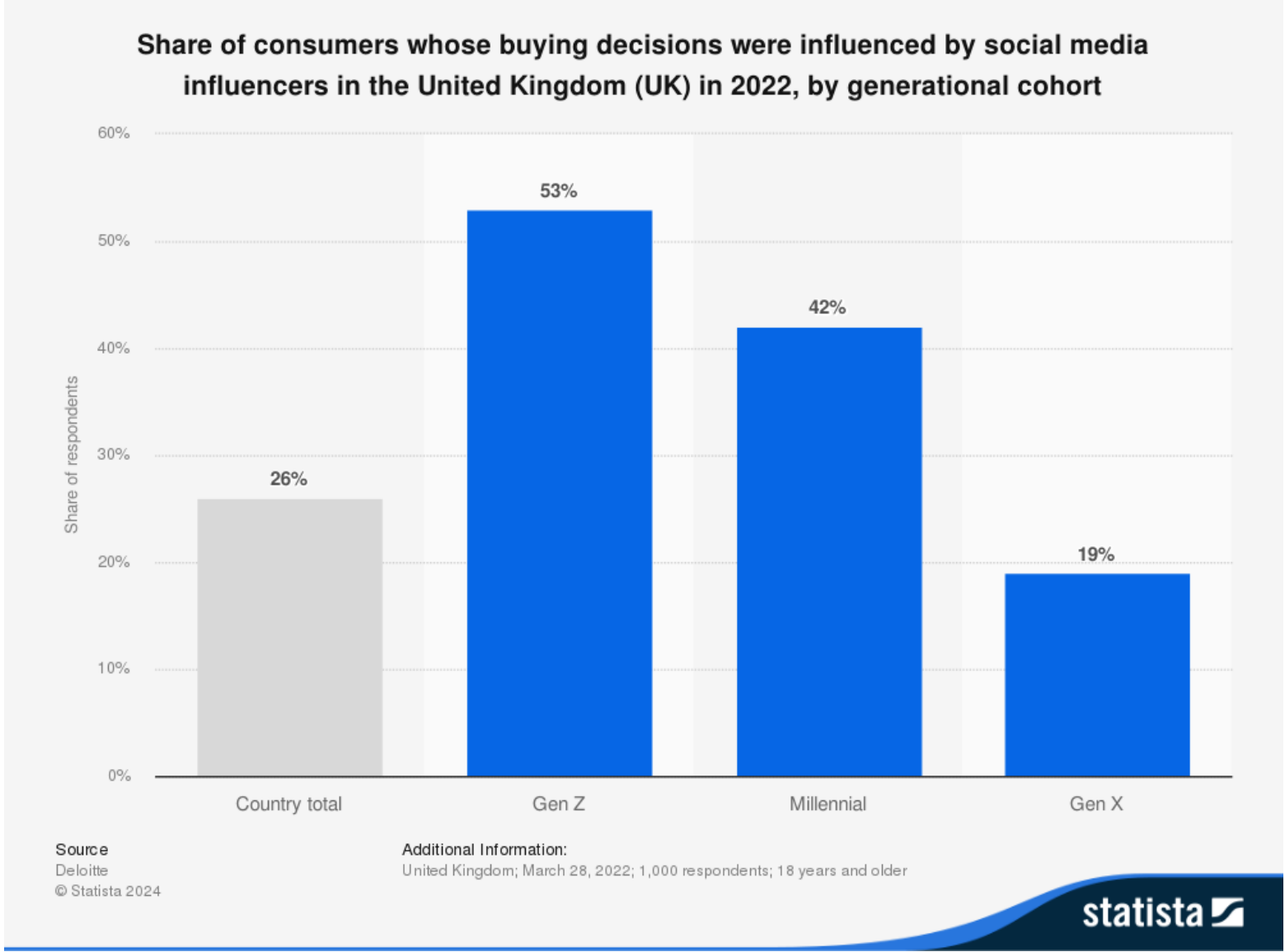
Influencer Marketing – Why is it important?





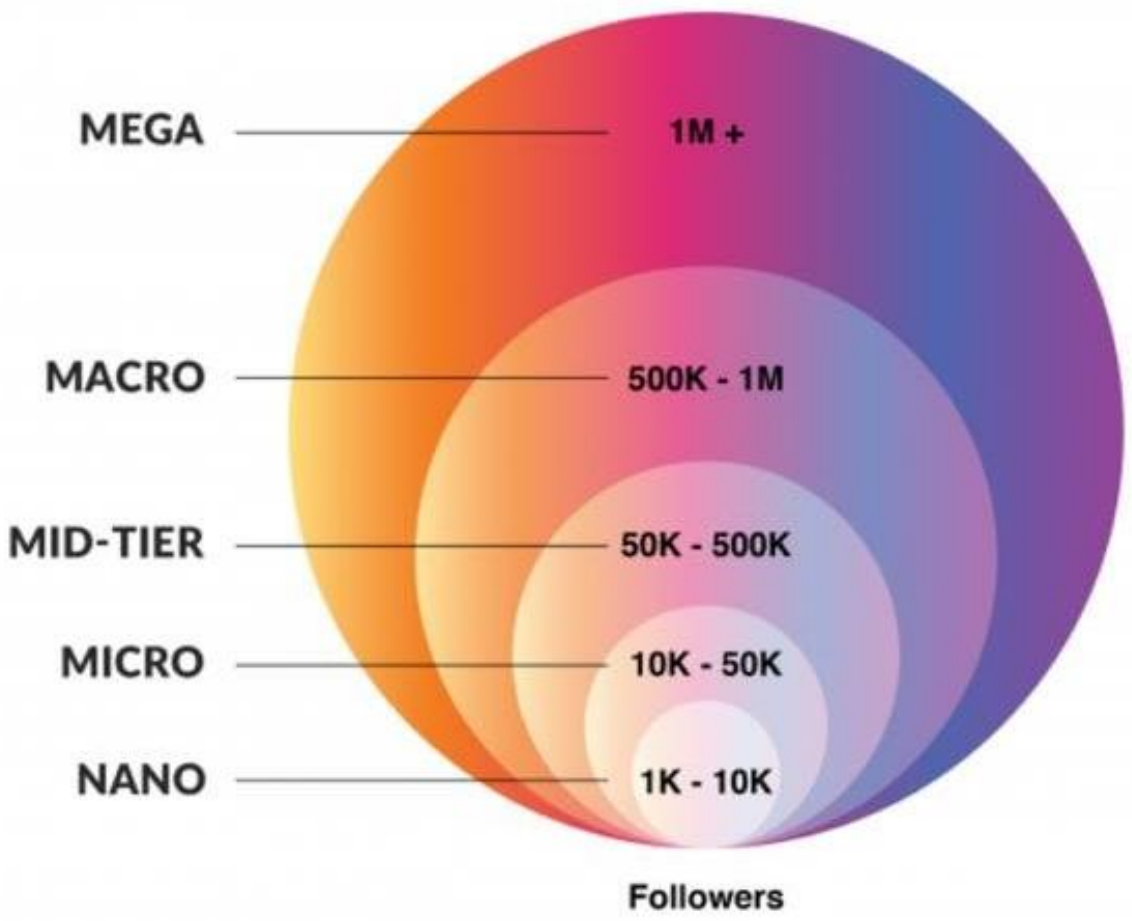
Influencer Marketing – Why is it important?





Types of influencers

Influencer Marketing – Tiers of Fame



Influencers are tiered by the number of followers they have.

As tier size increases…

- Overall reach increases
- Campaign cost increases
- Audience becomes more broad
- Relative engagement decrease

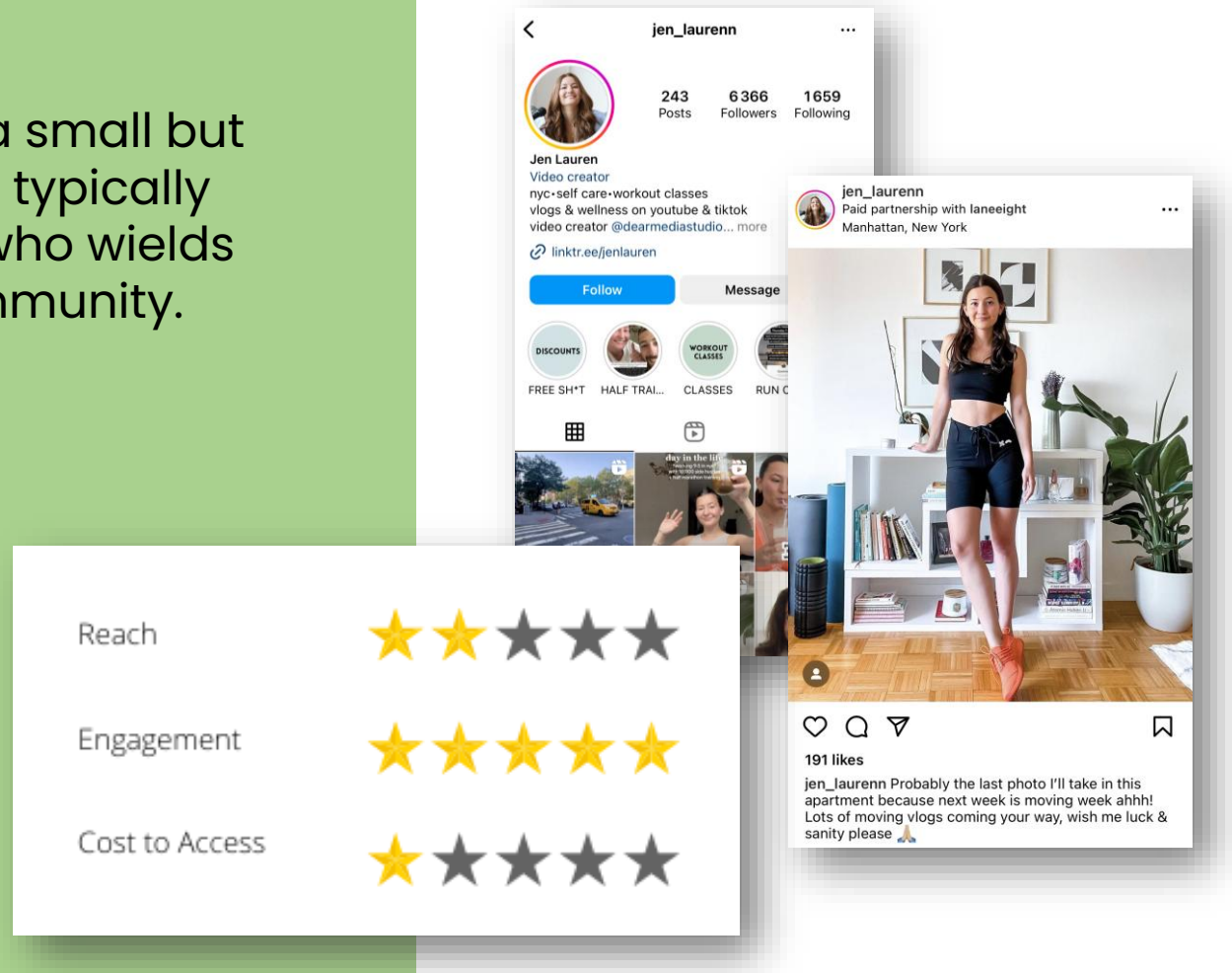
Important to consider influencer size in campaign decisions.

Nano-Influencer

<10,000 Followers

A nano influencer is an individual with a small but highly engaged social media following, typically ranging from 1,000 to 10,000 followers, who wields influence within a specific niche or community.

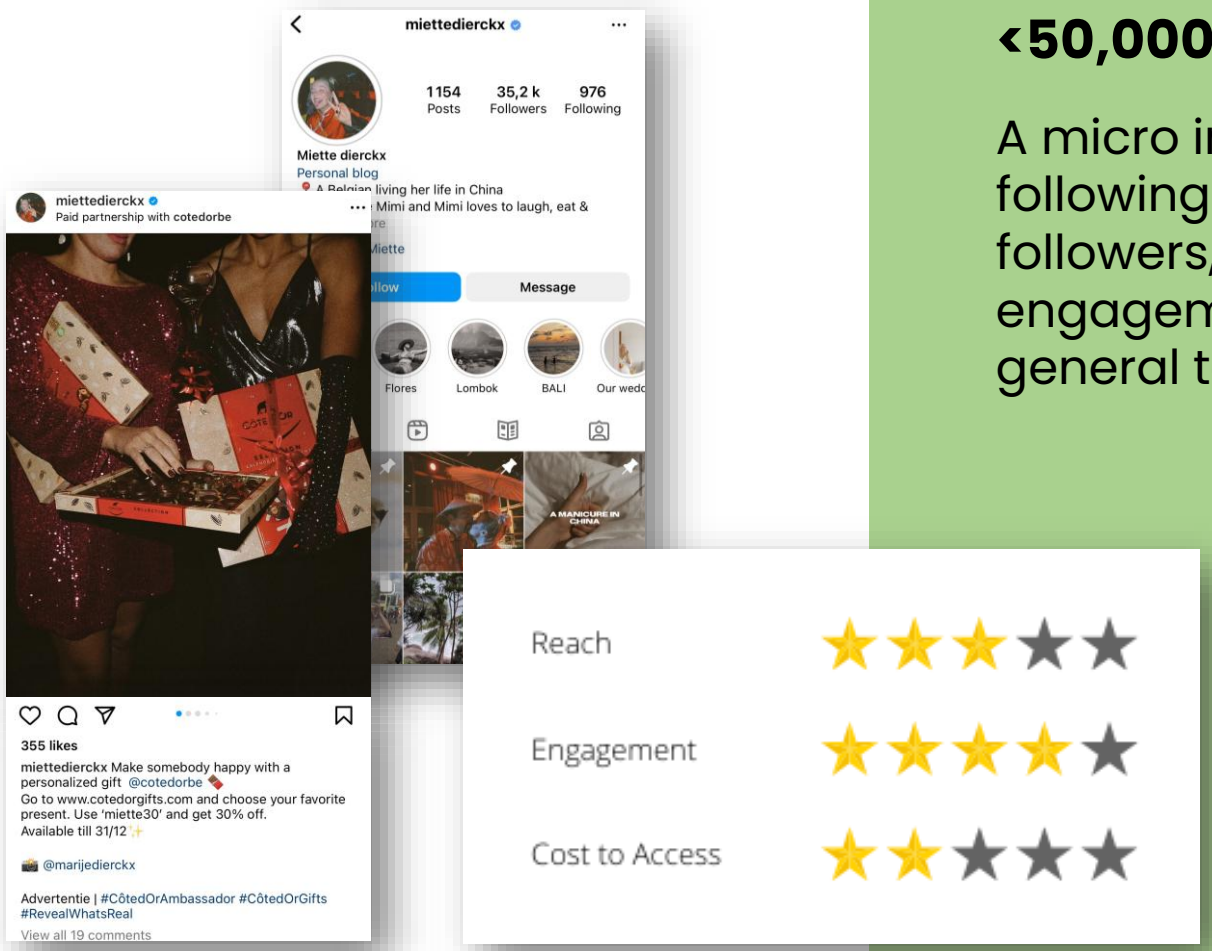
- Niche focus
- Very high engagement
- Very high authenticity
- Strong community
- Cost effective



Micro-Influencer

<50,000 Followers

A micro influencer is an individual with a social media following typically ranging from 10,000 to 50,000 followers, known for their niche expertise and high engagement rates within specific communities or general topics.



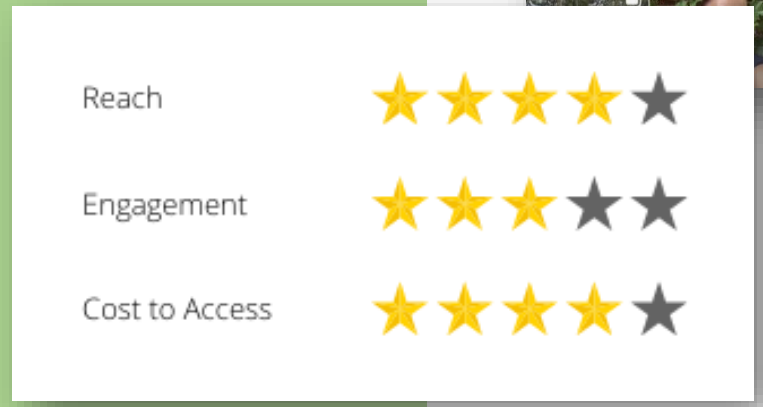
- More general focus
- High engagement
- High authenticity
- Growing influence

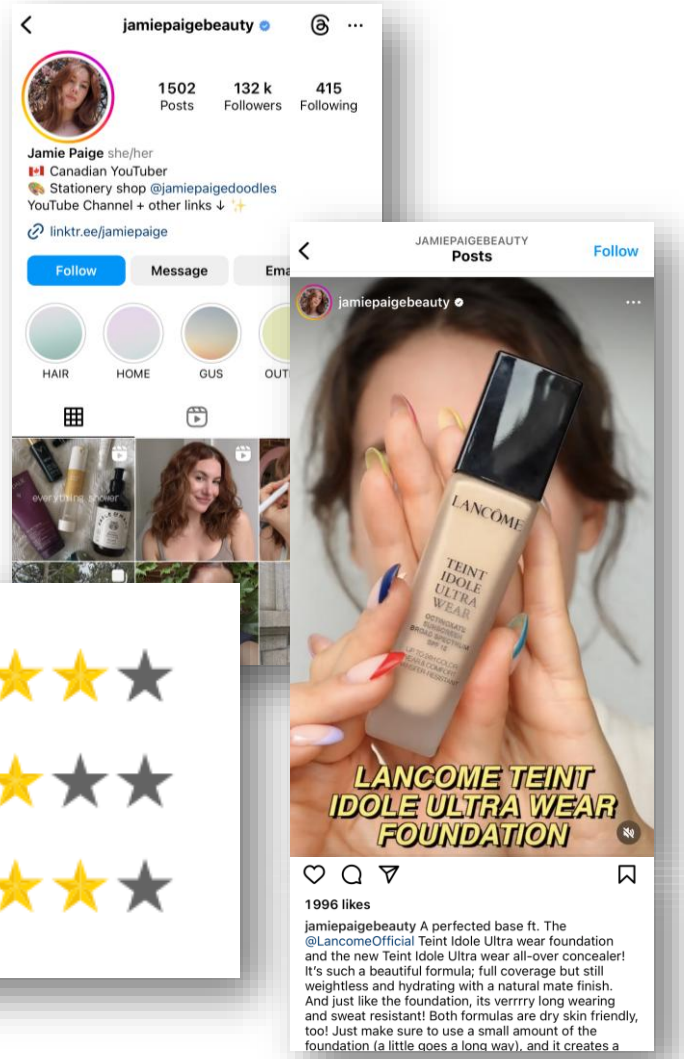
Macro-Influencer

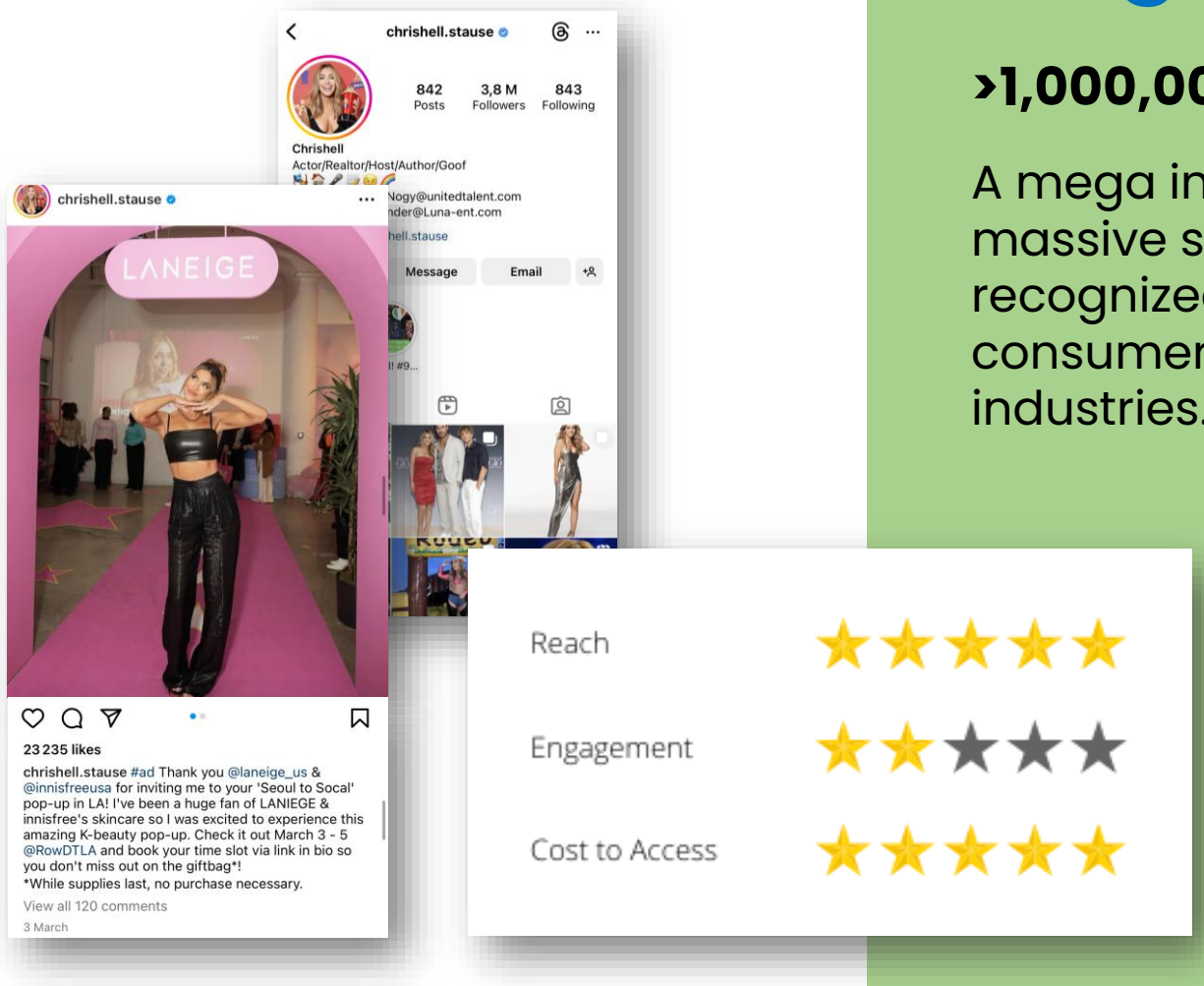
<1,000,000 Followers

A macro—influencer has a substantial following typically ranging from 500,000 to 1 million followers, capable of reaching and influencing a large audience with their content and endorsements.

- High reach
- Established presence
- Influential power
- Diverse content
- High cost







Mega-Influencer

>1,000,000 Followers

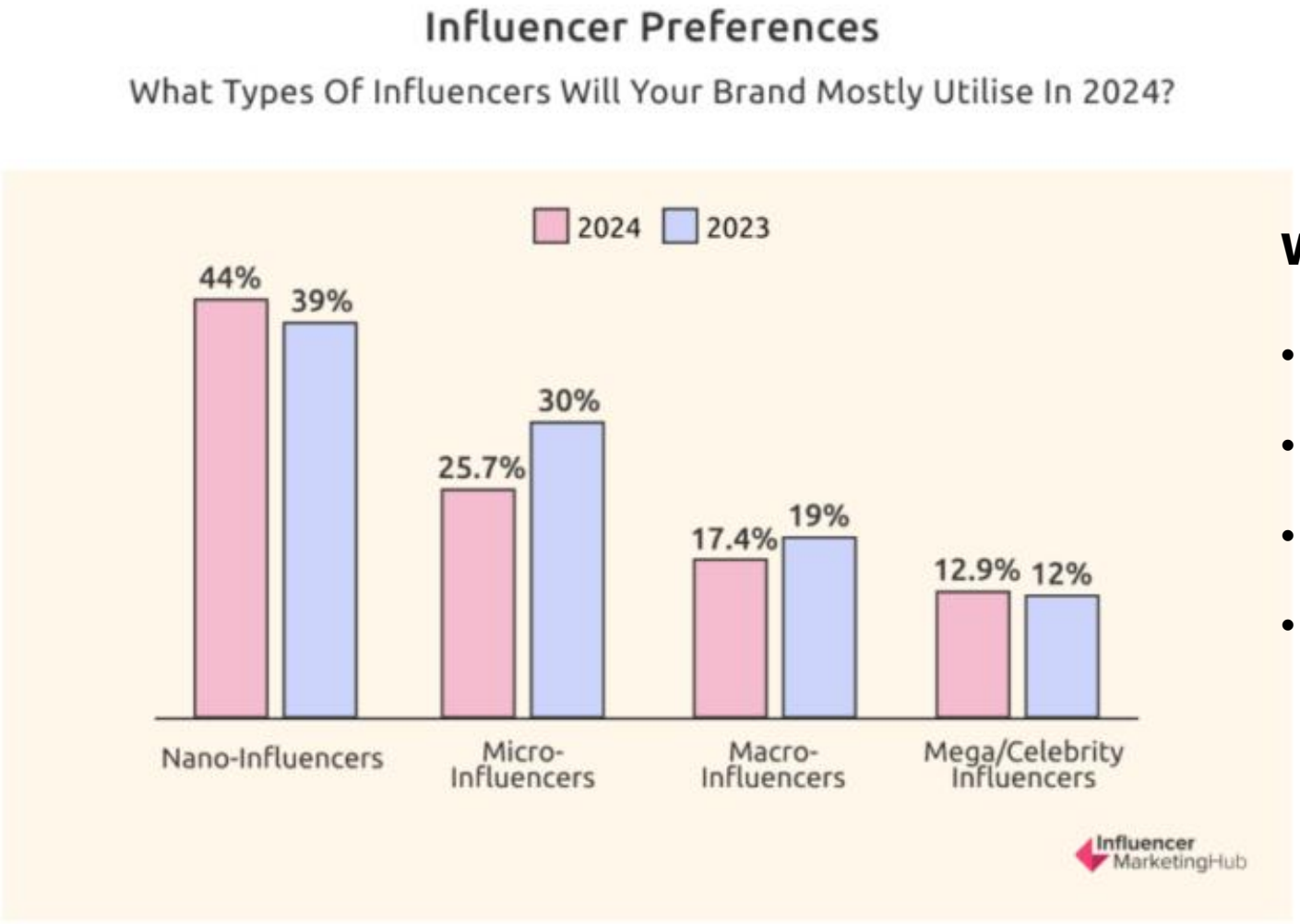
A mega influencer is a highly prominent figure with a massive social media following exceeding 1 million, recognized for their substantial impact on trends and consumer behaviour across diverse platforms and industries.

- Very large reach
- Diverse audience
- Significant influence
- May impact trends
- Highest cost





Influencer Marketing – Brand Preferences

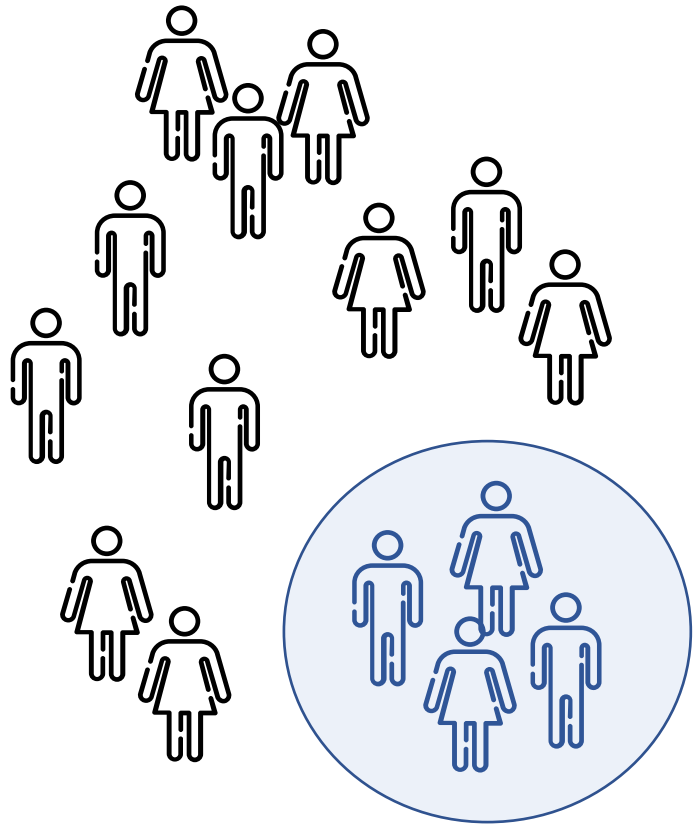


Why Nano- / Micro-Influencers?

- More relative engagement
- Hyper-niche targeting
- Greater control
- More cost-effective

Influencer Marketing Benefits & Threats

Targeting Benefits – Homogeneity of Audience

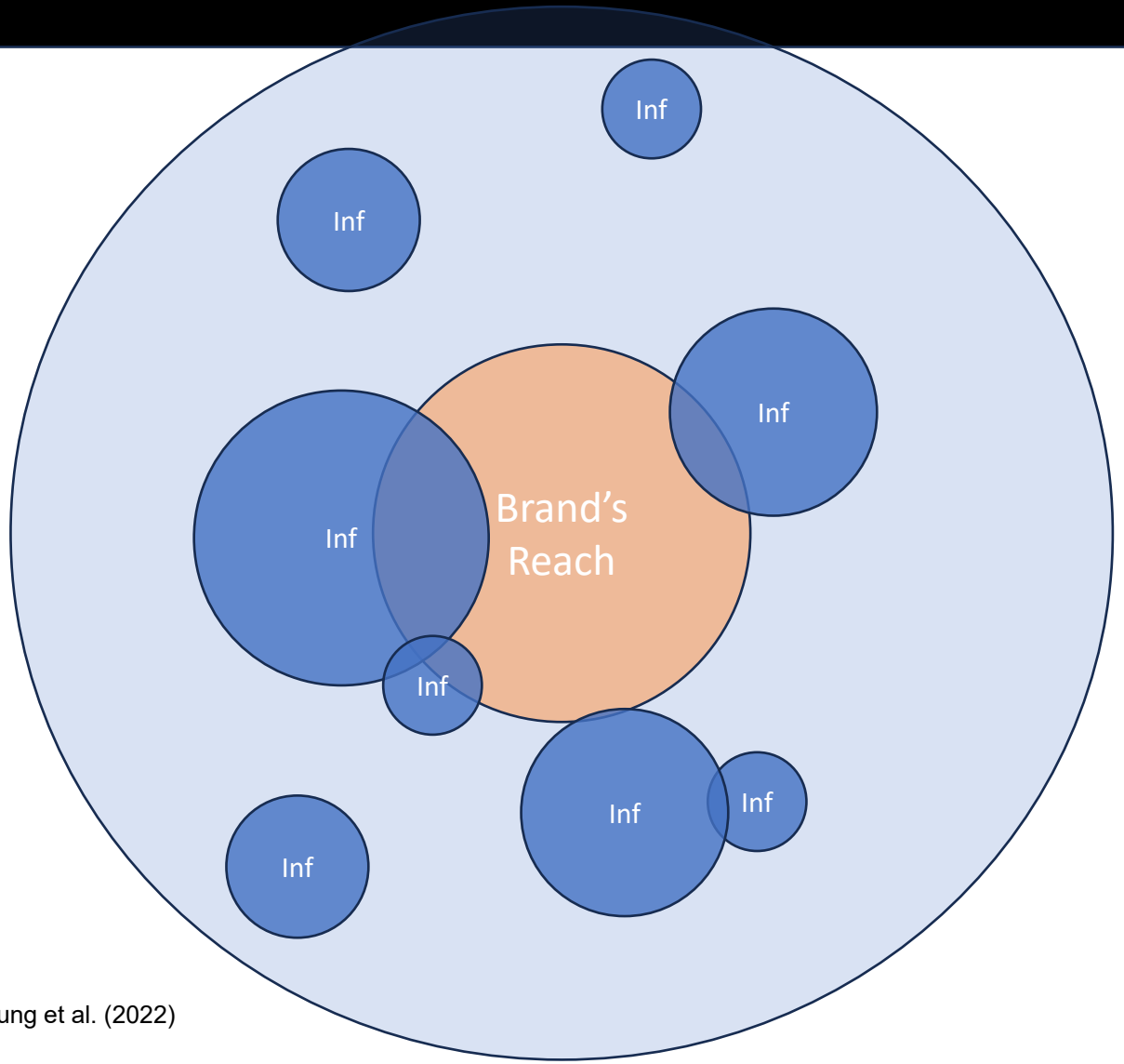


Segment Homogeneity

- Refers to the ‘Uniformity of Audience’
- Similar demographics, interests, behaviours, or preferences
- Helps in reaching specific customer segments

Source: Leung et al. (2022)

Targeting Benefits – Segment Dynamism & Reach



Source: Leung et al. (2022)

- 100% of the audience
- Brand's current reach
- Influencer's current reach

- Ability to access networks that are outside of the brand's current reach
- Allows for greater expansion & awareness
- Influencer followings are dynamic, and may change in composition over time

Positioning Benefits

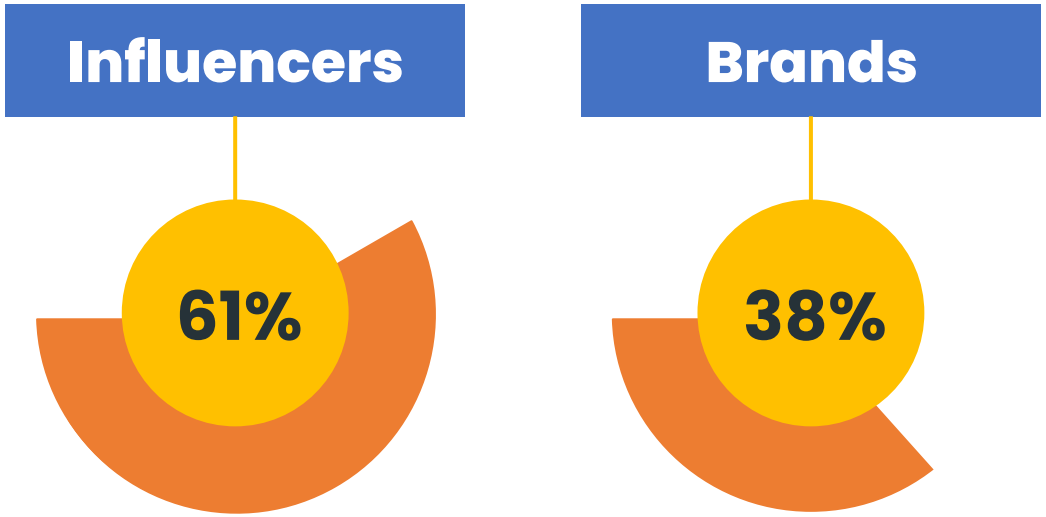


Positioning	**Step 3: Communicating and delivering the chosen position to the market**

Trust Benefits

Trust & Authenticity
Influencers vs. Brands

Who do consumers find more trustworthy?



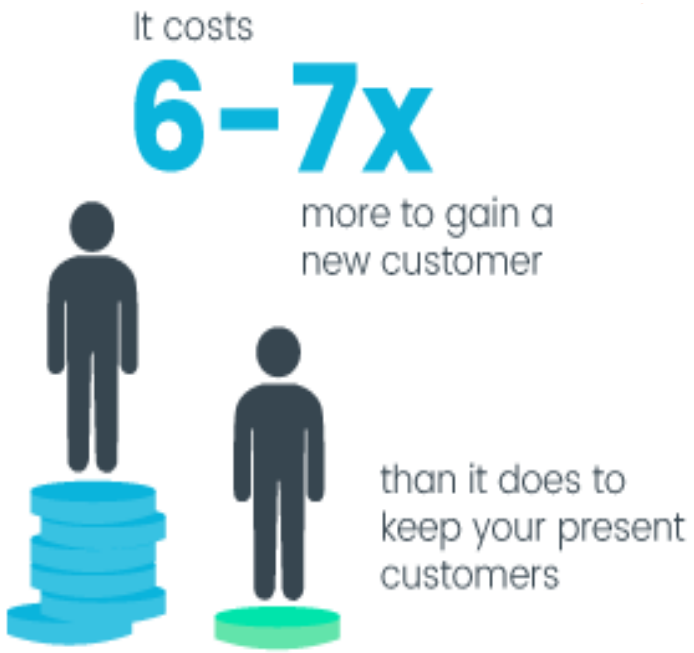
Source: Business Wire (2023)

Customer Retention Threat

Influencers may help get your customers foot through the door, but it's your job to keep them in!

Firm-led behaviours dominate in importance for retention…

- Personalisation
- Exceptional customer service
- Loyalty programs
- Community building





Source: Leung et al. (2022)

Influencer Selection

Factors that affect influencer selection

Objectives
Desired outcomes and KPIs

Target audience
Understand your audience and pick influencers who align with your target

Brand values
Shared values, e.g. an eco-conscious brand avoids fast-fashion promoters

Relevance to brand offerings
Your products fit naturally in their feed and niche

Influencer characteristics
Authenticity, credibility, follower size, cost

Engagement rates
How actively followers respond to their content

ENGAGEMENT RATE BY POST

$$\text{Engagement rate} = \frac{\text{Total engagements on a post}}{\text{Total followers}} \times 100$$

Source: Georgiadis (2022)

Learning Outcomes - Recap

Now, you should be familiar with the following concepts:

- Content marketing:
  - Content marketing funnel
  - Content marketing strategies
- Influencer marketing
  - Types of influencers
  - Benefits and threats

Seminar 5:

Engagement & Content Marketing

Next week's lecture…

Consumer behaviour & Customer insight in the digital age